ROMISED'

are of course issues. But we will definitely take people into confidence. Once people start getting benefits of industrialisation, they will not object. With infrastructure and industry, we are creating better opportunities for our people and posterity.

'Odia Asmita' was one of your major poll planks. What do you mean by it and what has your govt done in this regard? What about the issues like Kotia, Deomali and other border villages are facing?

Apart from celebrating and taking pride in rich cultural heritage of Odisha, Odia Asmita is also Odia identity. It means celebrating everything that is linked to Odisha and Odia. We are celebrating the life and works of all our forgotten heroes. We celebrated Odia Pakhya (fortnight) for the first time in Odisha, a 14-day festivity, each day linked to one specific cultural glory of the state. In fact, we have a long list of initiatives on this count.

Odia Ashmita is closely linked to protection of Odia language, cultural heritage and literature as well. Immediately after assuming office, the government directed to make all forms of communication in Odia only, which has already been implemented. Similarly, the government is encouraging Odia writers, poets. From KG to PG, all teachings will be in Odia medium only. We are working to write the required text books in Odia language.

I don't think Deomali is any issue. There are some environmental issues regarding creating infrastructure in the tourist place there. Regarding Kotia, it is a long-standing issue. There were some neglect in the past which we are correcting now. We are improving our outreach to the locals with focus on holistic development in those areas.

Odisha has a major problem of its people migrating to other states as labourers in massive scale. Are you doing something seriously to check this menace?

The issue of migration has a long-standing problem which unfortunately never got the attention it deserved. We have formed a Task Force to deal with it under the chairmanship of Deputy Chief Minister. In the meantime, we are undertaking massive industrialisation of Odisha. All the 30 districts of the state will see this in the coming days.

Besides, consciously we are spending massively as capex. During this year's budget, a massive Rs 65,012 crore amounting to 6.1% of GSDP, probably highest in India in percentage terms to GSDP. This massive expenditure will create jobs and employment.

THE JOURNEY SO FAR

POLITICAL CAREER

- **1995:** Lost Assembly polls as Independent candidate from Keonjhar (ST) constituency
- **1997-2000:** Elected and served as Sarpanch of Raikala village
- **2000:** Elected as MLA from Keonjhar as a BJP candidate
- **2004:** Re-elected as MLA from the same constituency
- **2005-2009:** Served as the Government Deputy Chief Whip in the Assembly
- **2009 & 2014:** Contested the Assembly elections from Keonjhar but lost both times
- **2019:** Re-elected as MLA from Keonjhar and appointed as the Chief Whip of BJP in the Assembly
- **2021:** His vehicle was attacked with crude bombs by unidentified assailants in Keonjhar; he escaped unhurt
- **2022-24:** Chaired the Public Accounts Committee (PAC) overseeing government expenditures
- **2023:** Suspended from the Odisha Assembly while protesting against Rs 700-crore scam in mid-day meal scheme
- **2024:** Re-elected as MLA from Keonjhar and sworn in as the 15th Chief Minister of Odisha on 12th June 2024

FINANCIAL OVERVIEW (AS OF 2024)

- **Declared Net Worth:** Approximately Rs 12.43 crore
- **Movable Assets:** Includes cash, bank deposits, insurance policies, a 'Toyota Fortuner' vehicle and jewellery
- **Immovable Assets:** Owns agricultural land valued at Rs 19.2 lakh
- **Annual Income:** Reported income of Rs 4.22 lakh for the financial year 2023-24

This twin strategy will kick in decent amount of jobs and once jobs start coming in, there will not be any forced migration. People will travel outside the state anyway in search of better jobs, but our goal is to arrest forced migration. Nobody should travel outside the state for work on exploitative terms. Besides, we are giving a big push to the farm sector, where farmers can go for diversification of crops that will create jobs in agriculture and allied sectors in all seasons.

Odisha is dependent on its neighbours for most of the consumables, especially agricultural products. What efforts your govt is taking to make the state self-sufficient?

Unfortunately, in previous years, too much emphasis was given on paddy cultivation at the expense of other fruits and vegetable. But, we have made a course correction. For vegetables production and storage, cold storages and cold-rooms are being set up. Special grants are given to farmers to produce crops like potato, onion, spices, cash crops etc. The result will show in next few agricultural seasons.

Schemes and initiatives have already been launched like the Kamadhenu Yojana to improve milk production. Similarly, we have made specific plans to increase fish, egg and vegetables production. I believe we will be self-sufficient in a few years.

How effective is the "double-engine govt"? Is it only limited to syncing or implementation of the national schemes at the state level?

Firing from all cylinders… Double engine government means convergence in policies and programs. Apart from syncing with Central government programs, we are also getting support in our own initiatives. Since our government came to power, the Central government has sanctioned infrastructure projects worth about Rs 1 lakh crore in railways and roads. Many Central institutes like National Forensic Science University are opening their campus here.

You have a smaller Cabinet than prescribed... only 75% is filled, and distribution of portfolios also does not seem quite balanced. Do you have an expansion plan in near future?

The government is working on the theme 'Minimum Government, Maximum Governance' which is doing pretty well. I will undertake expansion as and when necessary.

Your government is just one year old and people's expectations are very high. What are the main challenges you think you are going to face in the coming days in realising your dream of Odisha?

We have launched huge initiatives in various sectors. We are also moving at a pace and scale never seen before. Our empowerment programs, employment and industrialisation initiatives have been massive success. There is no specific challenge.

I will again remind what the Prime Minister had said in his second visit to 'Niti Ayog' back in 2015: "Days of incremental development is gone. India now needs 'Transformational Change'." This is exactly what we are doing – doing things with Speed, Scale and without compromising Standard or quality. This will be the strategy to build Samruddha Odisha in next 11 years. We are racing against time and, yes we can do it…